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The Oracle, the Plague, and the Mystery of Oedipus' Identity in Natalie Haynes' *The Children of Jocasta*

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ABSTRACT
This article examines how Sophocles' play *Oedipus the King* informs Natalie Haynes' reimagination of Oedipus' story in *The Children of Jocasta*. In this post-modern novel of deconstruction and subversion, Haynes' reversal of two hierarchies in Sophocles' play marks her feminist stance. While disempowering the gods by dramatising Jocasta's scepticism and pragmatism, the novel empowers the Thebans, whose voice determines Oedipus' fate during a plague. Haynes' rearrangement of events, change of relationships, and reversal of hierarchies reflect her skills as a classicist and concerns as a feminist. By stressing Oedipus' and Jocasta's defiance, Haynes portrays them as loving parents, passionate lovers, sensible rulers, and trustworthy friends, thereby according them considerable agency and subverting their images in classical narratives as the gods' playthings.

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Introduction

In her article on Madeline Miller's *Circe*, Valeria Spacciante comments on "what is probably the biggest revival of ancient mythology in novels written in English" in the last decade.[1] She notes that "authors like Madeline Miller, Pat Barker, Jennifer Saint, Natalie Haynes, and many more have been retelling the Graeco-Roman myths from their female characters' perspective, usually marginalized in the ancient versions of these stories".[2] This "switch in perspective, from the male heroes to the marginal female characters"[3] characterises Natalie Haynes' novel *The Children of Jocasta*, a retelling of the story of Oedipus from the perspective of Jocasta, a peripheral character in the classical stories. Haynes turns Oedipus' tragedy into Jocasta's bildungsroman and chronicles her growth from an innocent girl to a sophisticated ruler of Thebes, thereby complicating the image of a woman whose story occupies less than "even a tenth of the whole" of Sophocles' *Oedipus the King*.[4] In addition, Haynes reverses the characters' fortunes. For example, in Sophocles' *Antigone*, Polyneices starts a ruinous war against Thebes

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[1]Spacciante, "Circe, the Female Hero," 405.
[2]Ibid.
[3]Ibid., 406.
[4]Haynes, *Pandora's Jar*, 42.

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and is refused burial as a result[5], whereas in *The Children of Jocasta*, his brother Eteocles is condemned as a traitor whose corpse is exposed. Whereas Antigone secretly buries her brother against the law of the state in Sophocles′ play, in Haynes′ novel, that loving sister′s role is appropriated by Ismene. Similarly, in *Antigone*, Antigone is imprisoned by Creon and dies in an underground cell, while in *The Children of Jocasta*, she obtains the crown of Thebes and has Creon executed. Do these reversals suggest the reversal of Oedipus′ fate, or his exemption from a tabooed relationship? By studying Haynes′ reversal of two of the hierarchies in Sophocles′ *Oedipus the King*, this article asks whether these reversals ultimately clear Oedipus of the guilt of patricide and incest, thereby entirely subverting his stereotypical image as the most wretched man in the world.

Sophocles stresses Oedipus′ patricide and incest as solid facts. The messenger from Corinth and the shepherd from Kithairon witnessed him being deserted, saved, and adopted by another family, thereby proving the blood relations between Oedipus and Laios and the truth of the god′s oracle. At the end of the play, Oedipus blinds himself in acknowledgement of the terrible truth of being Laios′ son and murderer and soon his "misfortunes" are known to everyone in Greece.[6] In modern times, psychoanalysts have defined the Oedipus complex as part of a man′s psychic reality. In his *Interpretation of Dreams*, Sigmund Freud concluded after an analysis of *Oedipus the King* that "It is the fate of all of us, perhaps, to direct our first sexual impulse towards our mother and our first hatred and our first murderous wish against our father"[7] and coined the term "the Oedipus complex" to refer to that incestuous wish, part of the universal human psyche, which an infant boy harbours towards his mother. Freud′s student, Carl Jung, informed by the theory of the Oedipus complex, coined the term "anima" to refer to an essential part of a man′s collective unconscious that is a conflation of his mother and his lover.[8] While both classical authors and modern psychoanalysts take it as established beyond doubt that Oedipus killed his father and married his mother, perhaps we should ask whether they were not mother and son, but simply husband and wife – perhaps they were wronged by ancient authors and patriarchal culture. A central question this article asks is whether Haynes′ undermining of the god′s authority in her retelling can destabilise or even subvert the mother – son relationship between Oedipus and Jocasta.

Natalie Haynes, a British broadcaster and writer, has published five novels, three of which retell ancient myths: *The Children of Jocasta*, *A Thousand Ships*, and *Stone Blind*. A "self-declared ′classics nerd′ who has made her career reinventing Greek myths for a modern readership", Haynes demonstrates an unparalleled love for classical stories.[9] Her story about life in modern Edinburgh, *The Amber Fury*, for example, is informed by *Oedipus the King*, Euripides′ *Alcestis*, Aeschylus′ *Oresteia*, and Ovid′s *Metamorphoses*. *The Children of Jocasta* reflects aspects of many classical tales as well: all the odd chapters are based on Sophocles′ *Antigone* and all the even chapters on his *Oedipus the King*; the retelling of the conflict between Oedipus′ two sons is informed by

[5]Sophocles, *Antigone*, lines 186–92, p. 17.
[6]Sophocles, *Oedipus at Colonus*, lines 660–1, p. 61.
[7]Freud, *The Interpretation of Dreams*, 296.
[8]Jung, *The Archetypes and the Collective Unconscious*, 54–72.
[9]O′Keeffe, "Natalie Haynes," para. 1.

Aeschylus' *Seven against Thebes* and Euripides' *Phoenician Women*; and the final chapter of the novel has echoes of Sophocles' *Oedipus at Colonus*. Haynes does not simply bring these classical texts together; she rearranges events, changes human relationships, and reverses social hierarchies for a uniquely post-modern and post-structuralist retelling. Through an intertextual reading of *The Children of Jocasta* and *Oedipus the King*, this article examines whether Haynes' rewriting of two essential relationships in the source play changes Oedipus' fate and frees him from the crimes of patricide and incest.

Jocasta: "All Those Oracular Voices Meant was Nothing, Nothing"

Haynes dedicates a chapter of her non-fiction book *Pandora's* Jar to the portrayal of Jocasta in classical sources. Like Haynes' other female characters, the scant information available about Jocasta renders her almost entirely a cypher: "just over 120 lines" in Sophocles' "1530-line play [*Oedipus the King*]", and only "ten short lines" in Homer's *Odyssey*.[10] In a novel that is also Jocasta's bildungsroman, Haynes complicates her image by emphasising her roles as a loving mother and passionate lover. For example, a considerable part of the novel describes her excruciating suffering after losing her first baby because of the god's forewarning of patricide. Also, Haynes depicts Jocasta's consuming sexual passions for Oedipus in several chapters. However, Haynes emphasises religious scepticism as her essential character trait and as the de facto ruler of Thebes, her defiant attitude indicates the ebb of the gods' influence in the city. In *Oedipus the King*, Sophocles portrays a Theban queen whose scepticism eventually gives way to fervent religious belief. After hearing Teiresias' accusation of Oedipus' patricide and incest, Jocasta boldly declares that "All those oracular voices meant was nothing, nothing".[11] Days later, however, seeing Oedipus' agitation over Laios' death, Jocasta prays to Apollo at the temple: "[H]elp us purify ourselves of this disease, / help us survive the long night of our suffering, / protect us".[12] Finally, when Oedipus is proven guilty, Jocasta hangs herself to acknowledge her acceptance of ill fate and belief in an all-seeing god. In the afterword to *The Children of Jocasta*, Haynes summarises and comments on Jocasta's change from a religious sceptic to a believer in the gods in the source play:

> Jocasta is intriguingly blasphemous in Sophocles' play; she tells Oedipus that gods and oracles can't be trusted. But when she realizes that something truly terrible is happening, she turns to the shrine of Apollo and begs him for lusis—a release. That interplay between religious scepticism and sudden panicked faith was the key to part of her character.[13]

In *The Children of Jocasta*, however, Haynes portrays a Jocasta who turns from a sceptic into an atheist, thus reversing the development of her religious beliefs. Her encounter with Laius' housekeeper Teresa and the so called "Oracle" do not give her any trust in the gods, but deepen her scepticism until she loses her faith. In Jocasta's defiance Haynes reverses the god/ human hierarchy central to Sophocles' play.

[10]Haynes, *Pandora's Jar*, 42–3.
[11]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, line 948, p. 56.
[12]Ibid., lines 1170–2, p. 64.
[13]Haynes, Afterword to *The Children*, 329.

Oedipus the King recounts three oracles from Apollo: Laois consulting about his future child, young Oedipus inquiring about his parentage, and Kreon asking about the cause of the plague. All these oracles suggest that Oedipus will kill (or has killed) his father and marry (or has married) his mother. In *The Children of Jocasta*, however, Haynes only recounts one oracle from the sun god, which suffices to kill Jocasta's lingering faith: Jocasta's learning from Teresa of a doubtful oracle marks the end of the myth of an all-seeing god. In *Oedipus the King*, Sophocles portrays a blind Theban seer named Teiresias, who is hailed as "the godlike prophet who speaks with the voice of god",[14] of whom the locals believe that "He, only he, knows truth", the divine truth.[15] Haynes' Teresa, however, is hardly the mystical Theban seer Teiresias of the classical stories. Her image as a woman possessed of a clear vision, a reversal of Teiresias as a man deprived of a vision, indicates an unfulfilled oracle and Jocasta's mistrust in her. As Haynes states in the afterword to the novel, her Teresa is the Teiresias of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, who knows more about sexual pleasures than divination.[16]

In *Oedipus the King*, an oracle tells Laios that he will one day be killed by his own son. Laios has his new-born baby's feet "pierced together behind the ankles" and orders people to "abandon [him] on a mountain, [and] leave him alone to die".[17] Years later, a young man from Corinth named Oedipus meets Laios at a crossroads and kills him in a quarrel. Oedipus turns out to be the son Laios abandoned many years before. In *The Children of Jocasta*, Teresa whispers a similar oracle to Jocasta about Laius being killed by his son, and when Jocasta gives birth to a boy, Teresa deserts him without the least hesitation, claiming that "The king cannot have a son, only a daughter. There is a prophecy which said he would be killed by his son. He won't allow that to happen".[18] Years later, a young man from Corinth named Oedipus meets Laius in the mountains. In his fight with Oedipus, whom he mistakes for a bandit, Laius "[loses] his footing" and dies.[19] However, whether Oedipus is the boy Teresa abandoned is never proven in the novel. Even if he is, he is not Laius' son but the son of a young guard named Oran. Aeschylus,[20] Euripides,[21] and Pseudo-Apollodorus[22] all stress the blood relations between Laius and Oedipus. In Euripides' *Phoenician Women*, Jocasta recounts how Laius learns the oracle concerning his tragic future:

> He [Laius] had no child, though long married to me, and so he went and inquired of Phoebus, begging him as he did so that we two should get male heirs for the house. But Phoebus replied, "King of Thebes, city of fair horses, do not keep sowing the child-begetting furrow against the gods' will: if you sire a son, your own offspring will kill you, and the whole house will be embroiled in bloodshed". But he yielded to pleasure in a drunken moment and sired our child … .[23]

[14]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, line 409, p. 37.
[15]Ibid., line 410, p. 37.
[16]Haynes, Afterword to *The Children*, 332.
[17]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, lines 941–2, p. 56.
[18]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 85.
[19]Ibid., 118.
[20]Aeschylus, *Seven against Thebes*, lines 945–60, pp. 161–2.
[21]Euripides, *Phoenician Women*, 213–5.
[22]Apollodorus, *The Library*, III. v. 7, pp. 343-5.
[23]Euripides, *Phoenician Women*, 213–5.

Oedipus the King has a similar storyline, in which Jocasta says, "Laios was doomed to be murdered by a son, his son and mine".[24] In *The Children of Jocasta*, Teresa tells the Thebans, "He [Laius] attended the Oracle, and consulted with the priests. They told him that he would one day be killed by his own son".[25] However, Haynes' imagined passionate love affair between Jocasta and Oran amends Sophocles' play and deconstructs his plot about the patricide. If the god is indeed all-seeing, why did he not see that Laius did not even have a son and was not killed by anyone, but died of an accident?

Teresa's oracle does not transport Jocasta into fervent belief. To the contrary, the loss of her baby drives her ever further from a god whose oracles "predict nothing, [and] guarantee nothing".[26] Her scepticism culminates in her toppling "Teresa's ugly little shrine" in the palace and "replac[ing] it with an almond tree".[27] This gesture of defiance is only a prelude to Jocasta's decentring of the gods in Thebes. *Oedipus the King* opens with a scene of the plague in which Oedipus the king sends Kreon to Delphi for Apollo's oracle. The sun god replies that only when Laios' murderer is "banished" or "killed" will the plague retreat.[28] When Kreon brings Teiresias in to interpret the oracle, he answers that Oedipus is the murderer and son of Laios and must be banished from Thebes. A messenger from Corinth and a shepherd from Kithairon then arrive, telling Oedipus that he was abandoned by Laios, saved by the shepherd, and given to the king of Corinth to raise as his own son. In *The Children of Jocasta*, however, Haynes portrays the plague as a highly infectious disease, thus rendering all contact with the outside world impossible. Jocasta, now a rationalistic and pragmatic ruler, imposes a quarantine that closes the city gate to the Outlying. She does not send Creon on a trip to Delphi to ask for Apollo's oracle. Teresa has already been banished from the palace and neither the messenger nor the shepherd is likely to come to Thebes under quarantine. The question then is whether Thebes, now isolated from the rest of the world, will guarantee her freedom from a cursed fate.

In *The Children of Jocasta*, Haynes reverses the god/ human hierarchy by portraying a Theban queen with largely modern sensibilities who debunks the myth of the dragon-men,[29] doubts the truth of the oracle,[30] and considers temple-goers "superstitious".[31] This image of a sceptic-turned-atheist counters that of the sceptic-turned-believer in Sophocles' play. Haynes' efforts to disempower the gods and empower Jocasta naturally rouse the readers' expectation that her relationship with Oedipus will be rewritten. In *The Amber Fury*, a student, Mel, asks what is "fate" and "destiny".[32] Alex, her teacher, interprets them as the "three Fates, called the Moirae" in Greek mythology, "who see the future as it will be".[33] In the case of *Oedipus the King*, Apollo is a powerful Fate who draws the

[24]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, line 938, p. 56.
[25]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 268.
[26]Ibid.
[27]Ibid., 185.
[28]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, line 123. p. 27.
[29]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 57.
[30]Ibid., 133.
[31]Ibid., 245.
[32]Haynes, *The Amber Fury*, 56.
[33]Ibid., 56–7.

"outline" of Oedipus' life.[34] If this god is rendered powerless, could he manipulate Oedipus' life into patricide and incest?

Oedipus the King

In their introduction to *Laughing with Medusa*, Vanda Zajko and Miriam Leonard comment on the feminists' desire "to make visible and to fill in the 'lacunae' of the tradition".[35] Emily Hauser interprets this "fill[ing] in the 'lacunae'" as "a reclamation of agency in the recovery of the female voice" common in contemporary retellings of ancient myths.[36] *The Children of Jocasta* exemplifies this post-modern desire to recover women's "voice" and restore their "agency" by centring the narrative around the consciousness and imagination of a female ruler. However, another important aspect of Haynes' "fill[ing] in the 'lacunae' of the tradition" lies in her centring the narrative of Oedipus' life on a peripheral relationship and an almost neglected hierarchy in the source play. By restoring what is neglected and foregrounding what is peripheral, Haynes creates a narrative that thwarts the general readers' expectation of exemption from a cursed fate, one in which her feminist retelling reads like a detective story. *Oedipus the King* is hardly a play about the danger of being a king; it dramatises the plight of being a mortal. In this play, when the plague hits Thebes, the ordinary people ask their king Oedipus to save them; Oedipus thus sends Kreon to Delphi to ask Apollo to save Thebes.[37] Although all three levels of the hierarchy of god/ king/ people are clearly visible in the play, Sophocles stresses the tension between god and king as central to Oedipus' tragedy. In the afterword to *The Children of Jocasta*, Haynes remarks that the gods are "so often his [Oedipus'] enemies" in classical narratives.[38] If Sophocles dramatises the battle of wills between powerful Apollo and powerless Oedipus and chronicles the god's repeated thwarting of Oedipus' efforts to take mastery of his fate, Haynes foregrounds another relationship in the novel as central to shaping Oedipus' fate, that between the ruler and the ruled. By complicating the relationship between Oedipus and the Thebans, Haynes turns a religious drama into a political one, endorsing Oedipus' claim in the source play that the story of his parentage is but a political conspiracy.[39]

In the afterword to *The Children of Jocasta*, Haynes states, "Sophocles' mythic Thebes owes something to fifth-century Athens, so I'm continuing a noble tradition of reworking the city (and the story) for my own purpose".[40] In *Oedipus at Colonus*, Sophocles depicts Colonus, a city near Athens, as Oedipus' final resting place. Haynes thus comments on this "least-performed of the Theban plays":

> A blind exile, he [Oedipus] wanders Greece with his daughter for a guide, and eventually settles on Colonus as the place where he will die, and be interred. … That is to be Colonus, ruled (at this point in its mythic history) by the Athenian king Theseus, of minotaur fame.[41]

[34]Berg and Clay, Introduction to *Oedipus the King*, 12.
[35]Zajko and Leonard, Introduction to *Laughing with Medusa*, 2.
[36]Hauser, "'Back from the Silence with Something to Say'," 196.
[37]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, lines 59–96, pp. 25–6.
[38]Haynes, Afterword to *The Children*, 333.
[39]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, lines 519–47, p. 41.
[40]Haynes, Afterword to *The Children*, 331.
[41]Ibid., 333.

In Sophocles' Theban plays, Oedipus comes from Corinth, is banished from Thebes and dies in Colonus, which Haynes reverses by making Thebes a replica of Athens (and of Colonus) and having Oedipus banished from Thebes (Colonus) and dying in Corinth. More importantly, by making Thebes another Athens, Haynes reverses the king/people hierarchy in the source play; Oedipus is in her novel a king victimised by his own position.

The Athenian setting brings Aeschylus' play the *Eumenides* and Haynes' ruminations on democracy to the fore in this discussion. The *Eumenides*, the final play of Aeschylus' *Oresteia*, tells the story of Orestes' acquittal in Athens of guilt for murdering his mother Clytemnestra. In this play, it is a jury of ordinary Athenians, not the powerful Furies, who finally decide on the life and death of Orestes. In her non-fiction books Haynes highlights the formidable power of ordinary people in this play in her discussion of the Furies and the Athenian legal system. Her musings on democracy are epitomised in the chapter on the ancient Athenian political system in *The Ancient Guide to Modern Life*: "But it is Athens that has always inspired us the most, with its extraordinary, seemingly impossible democracy".[42] In this chapter, Haynes describes a typical Athenian vote:

> On days when the Ekklesia—or Assembly—was held, the citizens of Athens walked to the Pnyx, a hill near the Acropolis (and a Scrabble-player's delight, now that proper nouns are allowed), listened to arguments for and against, say, a military expedition to Syracuse, and then they voted for or against the proposal themselves, by show of hands. The whole process was administered by ordinary men like them, who were appointed by lot.[43]

Not surprisingly, in *The Children of Jocasta*, important decisions are usually made as crowds gather in the marketplace or in front of the palace, which evokes the Athenian Assembly, where the fate of the city is determined by the populace, not the elite.

Sophocles stresses the people's role in accepting Oedipus as their ruler after he solved the Sphinx's riddle and destroyed her. Kneeling in supplication, the priest reminisces on this part of their glorious history to Oedipus: "Remember your love for Thebes. Your skill was our salvation once before. / For this Thebes calls you savior".[44] This is reiterated when Oedipus accuses Kreon of conspiring with Teiresias to dethrone him: "Most men would lust for a life like mine—but I did not demand my life, / Thebes gave me my life …".[45] However, this does not make Thebes the democracy that Athens was. The Thebans remain subjects, as is most apparent when during the plague, the priest, representative of all Thebans, asks Oedipus to "rule now as [he] ruled before" and deliver them from their trial.[46] In *The Children of Jocasta*, however, Haynes evokes Athenian democracy by foregrounding the people's role in almost every public act, from welcoming Oedipus as their new king to the anti-plague measures. The debate between Jocasta and the Secretary of the Treasury, a man named Amphion, is a reworking of the Thebans' welcome of Oedipus as their "savior" in the source play. This debate in a "public square" where many of the people have gathered resonates with the Athenian Assembly.[47] Jocasta's refutation of Amphion wins the support of the Thebans, who "[root] for her to

[42]Haynes, *The Ancient Guide*, 9.
[43]Ibid.
[44]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, lines 68–9, p. 25.
[45]Ibid., lines 522–3, p. 41.
[46]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, line 74, p. 25.
[47]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 157.

marry again", thereby making Oedipus king.[48] The ruler/ people hierarchy is reversed during the plague. Whereas in the source play, people rely on Oedipus to "deliver" them out of the crisis and "raise" them to their feet,[49] in Haynes' retelling, the rulers rely on the Thebans to finally win the war against the epidemic. Jocasta adopts the anti-plague policies urged by Sophon, an expert doctor of common origin who seeks the good of the people. Jocasta sends doctors to "[work] across the city",[50] soldiers to guard the wells,[51] and people to dispose of the corpses[52] in order to save the lives of the citizenry and minimise the devastation of the disease. The people's power reaches its apex in the novel when they dethrone Creon and elect Antigone as their queen.[53] This democracy that raises Antigone to the throne, however, lies at the core of Oedipus' tragedy.

While Sophocles depicts an amiable relationship between Oedipus and the Thebans, Haynes complicates that relationship by foregrounding the people's desperate mood under quarantine measures. In *Oedipus the King*, the people remain constant in their support of Oedipus, having seen the "god" in him when he solved the Sphinx's riddle and trusting the "god" in him when the plague ravages the city.[54] However, in *The Children of Jocasta*, their support wavers when the plague hits Thebes repeatedly despite all of Jocasta's preventative measures. When Oedipus first came to their city, they hailed him as their "saviour" because he killed the Sphinx, a gang of bandits in the novel and restored trade between Thebes and other cities.[55] That which made Oedipus a hero, however, makes him a demon during the epidemic. The Thebans believe that though they gained great profit from Oedipus opening the city gate, it also allowed the devastating plague to enter. "He [Oedipus] had changed Thebes from fortress to market. And now look where they were: placing offerings on the graves of their dead children".[56] Their "turn[ing] against" him eventually foments a rumour as damaging as the terrible plague.[57] As the plague strikes the city time and again, people's rational fear gives way to wild conjecture; the story spreads that Jocasta and Oedipus are mother and son and that it is their incestuous relationship that has infuriated the gods and caused the plague.[58] This rumour, resulting from the people's desperate search for a remedy to their seemingly never-ending disaster, is pronounced at a gathering at the palace gate; it soon is taken as a solid fact and becomes part of the city's history without proof or witness. The gathering at the palace again reminds the readers of the Athenian Assembly, which, according to Haynes, has the right to declare and stop wars.[59] While the Thebans' gathering at the palace and acclamation of Antigone as queen made her the Theban ruler,[60] the Thebans' guilt in the case of Oedipus lies not so much in dethroning him

[48]Ibid., 160.
[49]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, line 67, p. 25.
[50]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 265.
[51]Ibid., 204–5.
[52]Ibid., 205–6.
[53]Ibid., 305.
[54]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, line 58, p. 25.
[55]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 160.
[56]Ibid., 240.
[57]Ibid.
[58]Ibid., 244–6.
[59]Haynes, *The Ancient Guide*, 13.
[60]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 305.

as in creating a false history in which he is the suppressed and silenced Other. A girl's furious cry in the crowd that "the gods [are] punishing [their] city" because of the king's ruinous marriage is the Thebans' final verdict,[61] and in this quasi-Athenian Assembly, no witness arrives to prove Oedipus' guilt as in the source play. Neither is given the chance to defend themselves, with Jocasta's death from the plague and Oedipus' blinding and banishment by Creon. Therefore, what starts as a mere rumour grows into a solid fact written in the local history. The formidable power of the ordinary people is still felt many decades later when Oedipus' children are distressed by the story of their parents' incest.[62]

By depicting this power of the ordinary people, Haynes turns a religious drama into a political play; her retelling confirms Oedipus' claim in the play that the story about his parentage is merely a political conspiracy. In *Oedipus the King*, after hearing Teiresias' accusation of incest, Oedipus' response is one of shocked disbelief, after which he accuses Kreon of "conspiring" with Teiresias to dethrone him.[63] While Sophocles refutes Oedipus' accusation, Haynes accepts it. At the end of the novel, Creon "conspires", not with Teresa, but with the Thebans and Sophon to spread the possibly false story of Oedipus' incest everywhere and make it part of the city's history. Haynes highlights Creon forbidding Sophon from telling anyone, including their children, the truth of Jocasta's death and Oedipus' blinding, thus casting the tale that they died or mutilated themselves out of shame as a solid fact. In a discussion of ancient Athenian democracy, Haynes remarks on its inherent limitations: "The dēmos, or people, could be a terrifying prospect to the upper classes. They were a noisy, brutish mass: impetuous, emotional, easily led into stupid decisions".[64] *The Children of Jocasta* muses on the limitations of ancient democracy by dramatising the tension between the pragmatic elite (Oedipus and Jocasta) and the superstitious mob (the Thebans). In Haynes' retelling, Oedipus is victimised by the very democracy in which ancient Athens took pride.

Conclusion

In *The Children of Jocasta*, Haynes subverts two of the relationships in *Oedipus the King*. While her reversal of the god/ king hierarchy breeds the expectation (or illusion) that Oedipus will escape his cursed fate, her change of the king/ people relationship spatters him with rumours of incest. Her empowerment of Oedipus (in defying the gods) is followed by his disempowerment (his slander by the Thebans) and at the end of the novel he remains much the same as in the source play, pronounced a criminal and pollutant of the city. In Euripides' play *Hecuba*, Hecuba tells Agamemnon with much irony and bitterness when he is reluctant to offer her any assistance, "There is no mortal who is free. Either he is the slave of money or of fortune, or the city mob or the written laws prevent him from behaving as his judgement suggests".[65] This holds equally true of Oedipus, who is by no means the master of his own fate in either Sophocles or Haynes. In *The Amber Fury*, Alex, school teacher in a referral unit, asks her students to consider "whether Oedipus is better off at

[61]Ibid., 270.
[62]Ibid., 322.
[63]Sophocles, *Oedipus the King*, lines 750–1, p. 49.
[64]Haynes, *The Ancient Guide*, 19.
[65]Euripides, *Hecuba*, 24.

the end of the play or at the beginning".[66] After reading *Oedipus the King* and *The Children of Jocasta*, the readers would like to know whether Oedipus is better off in Sophocles or Haynes. In either story, he is condemned. While in Sophocles' play he is a true criminal, in Haynes' novel he is a likely public scapegoat. While Sophocles highlights the price of defying the gods, Haynes underlines the peril of being a king. While it may be hard to know which fate Oedipus prefers, being convicted by a god or slandered by the Thebans, it is important to note the feminist strategies Haynes uses to rewrite Oedipus' tragedy: first, her reconsideration of the god/ human relationship and second, her defence of wronged men and women in mythology.

In a novel aiming at subversion and deconstruction, Haynes' reversal of the god/ human hierarchy is crucial to her feminist strategy of reclaiming Oedipus' and Jocasta's agency and thereby portraying them as life-sized characters. Elsewhere in her writings, Haynes almost copies the god/ human relationship in mythology in portraying such characters as Paris in *A Thousand Ships* and Atlas in *Stone Blind*. For all Priam's and Hecabe's (Hecuba's) efforts to expose the infant Paris to death, the Trojan prince is saved, raised as a shepherd, and involved in the fatal contest among Hera, Athene, and Aphrodite for the golden apple. His role in destroying Troy was willed by the god, even before his birth. Themis' forewarning that Atlas should beware "a son of Zeus" only precipitates his doom,[67] for by mistaking Perseus for Hercules, he is ruthlessly petrified by the impetuous hero. In *The Children of Jocasta*, however, Haynes portrays Oedipus and Jocasta as Prometheus-like figures defiant of the god's oracle throughout the story. They are no longer ruthlessly manipulated by an all-seeing god and the agency this affords them allows the readers to see them as life-sized characters, i.e. passionate lovers, loving parents, sensible and responsible rulers, and trustworthy friends. These character traits, apparently absent in the source play, rouse the readers' respect and affection for them and run counter to their stereotypical images as the most miserable of people. In Aristophanes' *Frogs*, Aeschylus enumerates Oedipus' woes, describing him as "the wretchedest of mortals":

> As a babe newborn, and in winter,
> They put him [Oedipus] out in a crock, not to grow up to murder his father;
> Then with swollen feet he hobbles off to Polybus, then he marries
> An old woman, and his mother to boot, then blinds himself.[68]

In *The Children of Jocasta*, however, Oedipus is no longer the man hobbling with a stick of the classical stories. He is young, handsome, and strong, a man whose "eyes still [glitter] with flecks of gold", whose "unmarked skin still [shines] like ripe apricots", and whose "muscles [have] retained every defined curve".[69] Banishing Teresa from the Palace, he is no mere receptacle of the oracles of the gods.[70] Neither is he the piteous man married to "[an] old woman", but constantly loves Jocasta "jealously".[71] Oedipus wins the battle of wills between god and human, leading a life unfettered by oracles.

Though the disempowerment of the gods does not exempt Oedipus from a cursed fate and at the end of the novel he is still accused of incest, Haynes portrays Oedipus as

[66]Haynes, *The Amber Fury*, 65.
[67]Haynes, *Stone Blind*, 307.
[68]Aristophanes, *Frogs*, 468.
[69]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 218–9.
[70]Ibid., 184.
[71]Ibid., 185.

wronged by patriarchal culture and history, arousing considerable sympathy for a relationship that classical authors condemned. Haynes is known for her defence of wronged women in ancient myths. In *Pandora's Jar*, she defends Phaedra in Euripides' play *Hippolytus*, where she is portrayed as the wicked stepmother who slanders Hippolytus and causes his tragic death. Haynes believes that she is victimised by the competition between two powerful goddesses, Aphrodite and Artemis. "We also learn, much as it may pain those who want to decry Phaedra as a villain, that she is a victim in this plot, just as Hippolytus is", Haynes thus concludes.[72] In her novel *A Thousand Ships*, Haynes depicts Clytemnestra as a loving parent who kills her husband Agamemnon solely to avenge her poor daughter, Iphegenia, contrary to her stereotypical image as a jealous wife and a shameless adulteress. In *Stone Blind*, she reimagines Medusa as loving, tender, and altruistic, a counter-image of the malicious killer in classical narratives. In *The Children of Jocasta*, Haynes does not whitewash Oedipus and Jocasta with messengers from Corinth proving Oedipus' parentage and therefore his innocence. Rather, the heated argument between Jocasta and Oedipus concerning Jocasta's first child, exposed at birth by Teresa, hints at the possibility that they are mother and son without grounds for ruling it out ever arising. However, the plague and his position as king make the story of Oedipus' incestuous relationship with Jocasta sound more like the prelude to a rite of purgation. In *The Golden Bough*, James Frazer recounts the perils of being a king in olden times, including being sacrificed to gods in a time of famine, disease, or drought in the belief that the well-being of the land was closely related to the health of its ruler: while a young and healthy ruler promised fertility, a senile and enfeebled king only portended barrenness and vice versa. In the case of Oedipus, it is not so much his physical disease that pollutes the land of Thebes as his sin of incest with the queen. The Thebans believe that "no preventative measures could save them, not while the city harboured a king and queen who lived in a lawless, godless union" and that "[t]he city's only hope lay in purging itself of the pollution it contained".[73] Frazer's hapless kings were the precursors of the "scapegoat", a goat "ritually burdened with the sins of the Jewish people" and banished at a time of crisis.[74] Although embodying the corruption of the land, these kings were more often than not innocent, which lies at the core of Haynes' retelling of Oedipus' tragedy in which he is ruthlessly maligned by the Thebans during the plague. This makes Oedipus a dignified figure rather than a cursed one, wronged, like Medusa and Clytemnestra, by history and patriarchal culture.

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[72]Haynes, *Pandora's Jar*, 213.
[73]Haynes, *The Children of Jocasta*, 261.
[74]"Scapegoat". *Britannica Academic.*

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